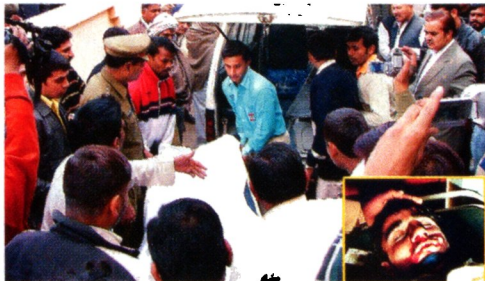


CHILDREN ON A RAMPAGE

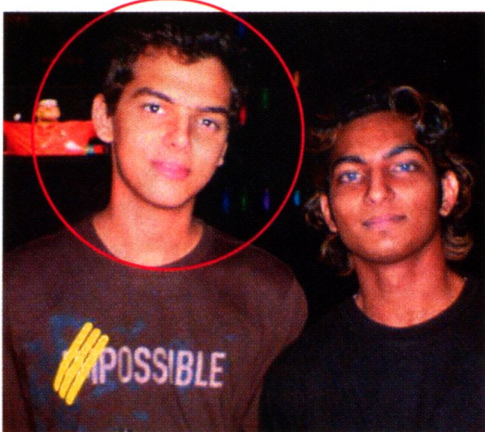
Some recent cases of brat behaviour that shook the nation...

DECEMBER 2007: India's first school shooting. Akash Yadav, 14, and Vikas Yadav, 13—both students of Euro International School in Gurgaon, pumped five bullets into a classmate for bullying them.



OCTOBER 2007: In a mayhem of media melodrama, Telugu megastar Chiranjeevi's daughter brought her celebrity father to his knees. She ran away from home, got married, sought police protection, moved the high court—televisually—to get her own way.

AUGUST 2007: Orkut member Adnan Patrawala's tragic death. Son of a businessman from Mumbai, he went out in his Skoda Octavia to play pool with some "friends". He called home around midnight to tell his parents that he "would not return that night". Three youngsters kidnapped Patrawala and killed him.



AUGUST 2007: A Class XI student of Nainital's Don Bosco Public School, Bhupendra Bist was beaten to death by his classmates during lunch break. Bist had intervened in a fight between two groups of students over the theft of a book.



JULY 2007: The police arrested the Chennai-based physician parents of Dileepan Raj, 15, who carried out a Caesarean section in his father's maternity hospital under their supervision in an attempt to set a world record.

MARCH 2007: The Mumbai Police picked up nearly 50 teens for spraying graffiti on cars and smashing property. These boys, most of them still in school, were marking their "territory" with their boy gang signature. They drove around in their cars at midnight and got high on beer. When questioned, they said they did it just for the craze and thrill of the act. Most parents of the accused confessed to being clueless about their child's activities, although some had earlier been cautioned by the police. Many gave false alibi and allowed the irresponsible teenagers to be on the loose.

present was a scooter that cost Rs 5,000. "We just couldn't get out of that," her father smiles.

Across the country, "life skills" training has become the buzzword. First used by the World Health Organisation to describe behavioural skills that help one manage life issues better, these were adapted by the Central Board of Secondary Education. Communication stands at the heart of life skills. Expressions India, a mental health support group for adolescents at VIMHANS, has launched the programme in over 150 schools in Delhi. NIMHANS runs a similar programme under Dr C.R. Chandrasekhar, head of psychiatry. "With rising competition, breakdown of families and clash of values, children easily fall into depression. Life skills help them cope up," he says.

Ask Pranav Sawhney, 17, student of DPS Vasant Kunj, Delhi. As a peer educator with Expressions India, he knows a lot about what ails his peer group. "Some kids crib because parents do not spend time with them," he says. Others have parents who say yes to everything. There are others who keep saying, "Our child cannot do this," even when they realise that children are getting into dangerous things. "Divorced parents often give in to every demand because they want to compensate for the trauma they may have caused." There are mothers who lose standing because they lack confidence and say, "I'll ask your father" for everything. He also comes across teens who hardly talk to their parents, because "they have nothing to talk about".

Rupa Murghai, student counsellor with IIT Delhi, is not surprised. She comes across a range of difficult parents: the overprotective, who organise every bit of their child's life; the perfectionists, who crowd out children's free time and imagination; the overindulgent, who can't set limits; and the disturbed parents, who make children feel inadequate. "A parent needs to be a parent, not a partner or a pest," she points out. "In the traditional set-up, it was easier for parents to pull back as children grew older." But with modernity kicking in, children have moved from the margins to the centre of the family. "And the struggle to set limits has become tougher than ever," she holds.

Are badly-behaved children culprits or victims? Countless sociologists have traced atrocious behaviour of children firmly to their parents. But that seems to be a bit of a whitewash at both ends. Parents are humans. And that means their emotions are sometimes bound to depart from the script. At the same time, children are humans, too. That means, to give them at least partial responsibility for how they turn out (and for whether they murder their classmates) is to take them seriously as fully human.

With Stephen David, Akhila Krishnamurthy and Renu Ojha